title. The very same day Akbar gave the order for the striking of square rupees. The purity of the metal used, the fullness of the weight of the coins, and the artistic execution of Akbar's varied coinage was exceptional and unmatched in the world, far superior to what was being manufactured under Queen Elizabeth I in England, for example. A great deal of the silver used in these coins came from the mines of Mexico, plundered by Spain and taken back to Europe, where merchants in England and the Netherlands would use it to buy commodities in Hindustan. Between 1586 and 1605, a staggering 185 metric tons of silver a year from overseas would pour into the Mughal heartland to become silver rupees. The influx of this silver, which made it possible to mint the coins, meant that this standard coinage would soon replace the copper-and-gold billon* and cowrie shells that were being used as currency in various parts of the country.

On the personal front, Akbar had some minor emotional issues to deal with because of his great Kayasth minister, Todar Mal. A diligent, sombre, and brilliant man, Todar Mal was one of the most accomplished examples of Akbar's 'men of the sword and men of the pen' system, a man who shone both as a warrior and an administrator. Though 'unique of the age for practical wisdom and trustworthiness', admitted Abu'l Fazl, the raja was 'at the head of mortals for superstition and bigotry'. Abu'l Fazl's disdain is clear when he notes that the raja would not begin his day before worshipping his little idols 'after a thousand fashions'. Now in the turmoil of moving, those precious idols were lost and the raja was heartbroken, neither sleeping nor eating in his grief. Whereas Abu'l Fazl was uncomprehending, speaking of his 'heartfelt folly', and calling him a 'simpleton', Akbar was a great deal more compassionate, tending to his friend and hard-working minister and consoling him for his loss till the raja recovered.

The year had been momentous for Badauni too. At the age of nearly forty, he had received the thrilling news that he had had a son, 'a happiness which I had been long anxiously expecting'. Badauni immediately went to the emperor and asked him to name the child, which he did, naming him Abdul Hadi, 'Hadi being a name which at that time was day and night upon his lips'. Hadi was, indeed, a common Sufi word and a Shiite term for God while Badauni was a declared Sunni. One of the imams of the court in fact urged Badauni not to use the name and 'commit this folly', but Badauni did not follow the advice, showing him to be, at this stage at least, not such a